Westbrook School Committee

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, August 12, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1217786673
Packet: No agenda was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org/page/westbrook-school-committee, 2026-10-24).

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *All seven regular members were present (Brooke Reed arrived partway through); no student representative attended. Every formal vote passed unanimously, but the Chair's report and public comment aired a real, sustained board disagreement over a member's social-media criticism of teachers' classroom donation wish lists — covered here at length with direct quotes. Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Reports

Superintendent's Report [3:17]

Discussion Summary

Three retirements: Reagan Hedstrom (science/environmental studies, Westbrook High School), Steve Mullen (STEAM, Westbrook Middle School), and Rob Jamie (computer repair/cybersecurity instructor, Westbrook Regional Vocational Center (WRVC)).

Back-to-school calendar: staff orientation and professional development days August 25–28; grades 1–12 begin August 31 (no staggered start); a series of building open houses August 31–September 15; first day of kindergarten September 2 (early release); first day of preschool September 3 (about 90 students).

Meeting schedule: the Chair flagged that Policy Committee was scheduled for November 25 — the night before Thanksgiving — and asked to move it; Policy Chair Erin Cavallaro agreed emphatically. Dr. Lancia said the full schedule would be rechecked for similar conflicts.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Principal Jeff Garrett's Update [8:28]

Discussion Summary

Noted recent building investments at the high school, including solar panels dubbed “Reagan's Rays” in honor of retiring teacher Reagan Hedstrom, an early advocate for the project.

Cell phone ban: Yonder pouches have arrived and will be distributed to students on the first day of school; violations result in confiscation, family notification, and progressive discipline.

Metro bus pass program (a one-year pilot funded by the City Council): detailed the two routes expected to see the most student use, intended to boost attendance for students in the roughly 1.5-mile walking radius. In response to a question from Dr. Flynn Ross about adult technology use modeling the same standard, Garrett said staff are expected to keep personal devices out of use during the school day as well.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

Chair's Report: The Classroom Wish List Controversy

Background & the Chair's Response [16:47]

Discussion Summary
After a community Facebook post invited Westbrook teachers to share their classroom “Amazon wish lists,” a school committee member publicly characterized teachers' participation as a potential violation of school policy, state law, and professional ethics. Chair Mancuso devoted an extended, prepared statement to the matter.

She reported that the district's legal counsel confirmed no Maine law prohibits or discourages staff from sharing classroom wish lists, and cited two board policies: Policy BCA (the committee's value statement, holding that “public statements criticizing employees are inappropriate”) and Policy BDB (which designates the chair as the board's public spokesperson except where specifically delegated). She reminded members that personal social-media posts about school matters are permitted, but should come from a “personal perspective as a community member or a parent,” not on behalf of the committee.

She cited a Portland Press Herald report (via National Center for Education Statistics data) that 94% of Maine public school teachers buy classroom supplies without reimbursement, and a 2019 Maine Center for Economic Policy estimate that Maine teachers spend an average of $356 annually on their own students. She announced that the Westbrook Education Foundation will work with Dr. Lancia on a permanent community-donation landing page, and that she and Katy Rice will work with Dr. Lancia to better quantify staff out-of-pocket spending ahead of the next budget process. Separately, she named Erin Cavallaro and Allison Brunette as the committee's representatives to Metro's new bus-pass advisory committee.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

Subcommittee Reports

Finance Committee — Noreen Poitras [24:05]

Discussion Summary
Topics from the 5:00 PM Finance Committee meeting held earlier that evening: the FY27 federal Title allocation ($1.2 million, with funds shifted to support Title I teacher salary/benefits); an ongoing payroll specialist search; the proposed special-education transportation van lease (see item 12.3); two new part-time School Nutrition positions at Canal School (see item 12.2); the FY26 audit still in progress; a concern about unusually high Sacarappa School electrical costs relative to WRVC, with usage data requested; continued Siemens solar-project savings; and a request to file the Adult Education warrant separately for audit-trail clarity. The Chair suggested a joint Finance/Facilities presentation from Siemens' own data representative on future energy

projects; Poitras agreed to coordinate with Facilities Chair Brooke Reed.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

New Business

12.1 — Nineteen Administrator/Teacher Nominations (Taken in the Aggregate), First and Final Approval [30:05]

Discussion Summary
Positions spanned every building: a CTE Exploratory Teacher and a Business Instructor (WRVC); a Grade 5 Math Teacher, Alternative Education Teacher, Grade 7 ELA Teacher, Special Education Resource Teacher, Grade 5 ELA Teacher, and Grade 7 Science Teacher (Westbrook Middle School); an English Teacher, a half-time Science Teacher, and a World Studies Teacher (Westbrook High School); a half-time Pre-K Multilingual Teacher, a Pre-K Teacher, and a Pre-K Special Education Teacher (Canal School); two Kindergarten Teachers, a Grade 3 Teacher, a Multilingual Teacher, and a Special Education FLS Teacher (Sacarappa School).

Katy Rice flagged that two different listed positions both named outgoing third-grade Sacarappa teacher Nancy Joyce as the person being replaced; Dr. Lancia confirmed this was an error to be corrected in the minutes.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 7–0, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Brooke Reed.

Action Items
None.

12.2 — Hire Two Part-Time School Nutrition Helpers at Canal School, First Approval [32:58]

Discussion Summary
Three hours each, to support the growing pre-K program.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 7–0, moved by Noreen Poitras, seconded by Katy Rice.

Action Items
None.

12.3 — Five-Year Lease-Purchase Agreement for a Special Education Transportation Van, First Approval [34:08]

Discussion Summary
Funded by Maine Department of Education pre-K funds. Up to $70,000 is available, but it remains unclear whether that figure includes financing interest or is in addition to it; Dr. Mazianis was tasked with confirming before a final vote.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 7–0 (first approval only), moved by Noreen Poitras, seconded by Dr. Flynn Ross. Expected back on September's agenda for final approval once clarified.

Action Items
None.

Important Dates

Upcoming Meetings [34:55]

Discussion Summary
September 9, 5:00 PM: Educational Programs Committee (Central Office). September 9, 7:00 PM: regular School Committee meeting (Room 114). September 16, 5:00 PM: Facilities Committee's year-kickoff meeting (Canal School). September 23, 5:00 PM: Policy Committee's year-kickoff meeting (Central Office).

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

Public Participation: The Wish List Controversy Continues

Public Comments Read Into the Record [35:19]

Discussion Summary
Erin Cavallaro read two public comments supporting classroom wish lists: Rebecca Allen, a second-grade teacher at Sacarappa, described her district-provided supply budget as adequate for necessities, with her personal wish list consisting of enrichment items beyond that budget. Aaron Druin, a first-grade teacher at Canal, framed wish lists as a voluntary supplement that can coexist with continued advocacy for strong school funding.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

> *“My whole point was I'm not in favor of teachers going out to the community. We go out to the community, we raise their property taxes. I do not have a problem if you do a wish list to your students … Another thing I had a problem with seeing on the Facebook page was seeing vacuum cleaners, carts, cabinets … I was always on the assumption that any wish list had to be pre-approved by the administrator at the school … Second of all, having a nurse ask for Tylenol, I have a big concern. Back in 1982, there was a big Tylenol scare. We will have no control over where someone purchased medicine like that.”*
>
> **— Noreen Poitras** [40:35]

> *“Every budget season we hear from taxpayers … that we need to control spending … and we listen … In the past two budget cycles, we have made multiple cuts to the per-pupil supply line … We can't provide a limited amount per student for classroom supplies and then pretend that it will cover every pencil, tissue, marker, book … over 175 days of school. It won't … I find it incredibly frustrating to hear some of the same voices that demand lower school budgets turn around and express outrage when teachers accept voluntary donations that supplement those budgets … You do not get to have it both ways. And I especially want to address the beyond wild suggestion that donating classroom supplies somehow amounts to bribing a public employee … The supplies aren't about currying favor with teachers, they are about the kids.”*

— Erin Cavallaro [42:13]

Procedural Note & a Finance Data Point [48:24]

Discussion Summary

The Chair allowed Cavallaro's remarks to run well past the normal three-minute public-comment limit, noting it has not historically been the board's practice to cut off its own members.

Poitras added a Finance Committee data point: $146,000 in unspent books-and-supplies budget districtwide last year (Sacarappa at roughly 18–19% unspent, Canal at roughly 19.42%). The Chair responded that the finance director had cautioned the figure spans many smaller individual accounts rather than one large pool, and suggested the administration examine whether supply funds are being tracked and maximized effectively year to year as a budget-season follow-up.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Announcements

Back-to-School Communications [50:02]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Lancia reminded families to watch for back-to-school communications; school offices reopen August 13.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. No agenda or back-up packet was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24); this summary is drawn from the video/transcript alone. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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